a political struggle—here Kashmiri subjects and the Indian state. This execution clearly establishes the fact of Otherness of Kashmiris in the Indian political imagination, and towards whom the Indian state would act under no legality or norm of human rights, far less concern itself with questions of citizenship rights. Toward Kashmiris the Indian state can only exercise its sovereignty—every act of the state in Kashmir is such an exercise, and therefore each act a display of India's 'national will'. For instance, the arbitrary imposition of curfews is not done to maintain any law or order, but is an unambiguous threat to Kashmiris that the Indian state has the power to choke life in Kashmir any time it wants.

The event of Afzal's execution has effectively foreclosed any politics via elections. It has emptied more than anything else the rickety discourse of those who had suggested a move to 'governance'. I think at this stage the actual helplessness in Kashmir should be felt by those individuals or groups who had put at stake their social lives and political interests to argue that a hyphenated 'India-Kashmir' was a possibility. They had remained obdurate in their defence of the oppressive Indian state even in the face of terrible atrocities visited on their fellow Kashmiris. For them it is over in the political sense. If they still nurse illusions of any possibility of India agreeing to free Kashmir from its military stranglehold and allow decent life conditions in Kashmir, it would happen only at the cost of losing the last shreds of integrity from their politics, if there was any in the first place. Kashmir's pro-India politicians have been pretending, or perhaps sincerely lamenting, that they have no power over major affairs of the state, including the removal of AFSPA. But they have been unable, or lack the courage, to draw the necessary conclusions about the vacuousness of elections and democracy in Kashmir.

This event has reaffirmed resoundingly the thinking of those Kashmiris who have for long set themselves upon a course to create an independent destiny for Kashmir. Tehreek—the Movement—has always been based on the fundamental principle of the irreconcilability of Kashmir's future within India, and India has proved yet again how right Kashmiri pro-freedom leaders have been.

Since the ideological obfuscation should be over now, the only thing that keeps Kashmir territorially tied to India is brute force and arrogance. Shaheed Afzal's body in Tihar is an apt metaphor for Kashmir's territorial connection with India. It is a body that doesn't belong in that land.